CANOE VALLEY SCHOOL

Vision Summary

Canoe Valley School envisions a community where learning is a whole-person, lived experience, rooted in place, shaped by human and nonhuman relationships, and carried forward by the curiosity and agency of young people. We imagine a school where self-directed, project-based learning invites students into meaningful encounters with the world around them, cultivating the confidence, creativity, and care needed to contribute to a more beautiful, just, and abundant future in an era where environmental and social challenges are proliferating. In this vision, students grow not only in knowledge but in purpose, discovering who they are by engaging deeply with the work, people, and places that call them into becoming their most unique and fully realized selves.

Institutional Characteristics

Who we aim to be as an institution. For more, see the Institutional Vision section of our draft Long Range Plan.

The school is designed as an accredited secondary school serving students aged 12–18 in two multi-age groupings, a lower level and an upper level. It operates as a nonprofit organization with a multi-stakeholder board that includes equal representation for parents, teachers, students, and community members. School leadership follows a teacher-administrator approach, with educators jointly sharing responsibility for academic, cultural, and operational life. Students participate meaningfully in school management and governance, including committee work connected to school operations and culture. The school emphasizes partnership with other alternative-education institutions and allied organizations in the community and region, and serves as a hub and anchor institution for work of a similar spirit in the Canoe Creek Watershed, greater Decorah area, northeast Iowa, and the Driftless region. The institution is grounded in the school's educational values, as well as institutional values like shared leadership and collective wisdom, relational agency, accessibility, and meaningful work.

Educational Values and Methods

Our proposal for the why and how of education at Canoe Valley. For more, see the Educational Vision section of our draft Long Range Plan.

We envision a form of whole-person education that is both new and inspired by longstanding alternative-educational traditions, aiming to draw out the one-of-a-kind qualities and purposes of each individual, in relationship to others and to the natural world. In practical terms, whole-person learning means supporting human development beyond the intellect alone. We aim to support capacities or potentials like self-motivation, self-expression, and relational ability, each of which involves our full experience, including the way we think, feel, sense, intuit, and so on. Our approach is unique in going a bit deeper than whole-person education sometimes does in naming and imagining these areas of human potential, and crafting a curriculum that arises from them. Each one is also an educational value unto itself: a core good that expresses what we think education is for, and that guides our learning and teaching in its own way. Our Educational Vision document goes into much more detail on each one:

- **Self-Motivation and Engagement:** How we follow our curiosity and persevere in what comes of it; how we show up to the learning process and to our efforts more generally.
- **Self-Understanding and Expression**: How we discover who we are, come to know and accept ourselves and share that with the world.
- **Relational Capacity and Interdependence:** How we find mutual support and kinship with others across difference.
- **Connection to Place:** How we cultivate connection with the more-than-human world and belonging in community.
- **Knowledge Foundations:** How we come to know the world, and cultivate skills that will sustain us in it.
- **Responsibility and Purpose:** How we offer something meaningful back to the world that has shaped us, and how we shape it in turn.

These six areas are far from exhaustive in terms of the various human potentials that education can support. But as aims, they are well supported by research and align with the values of families we aim to serve (see for example the results of our fall 2025 survey).

How do we support these areas of development in our students? If whole-person learning centers on fostering our innate curiosity and desire to learn, and on our unique identities, then the educational experience we provide needs to be meaningfully self-directed. It needs to provide expansive freedom for students to learn in a way that derives from their own agency and reflects who they are. On the other hand, if whole-person learning happens in meaningful relationship with others, with the nonhuman world, and within communities, and is oriented toward meaning and change in a broader social context, it needs to go beyond self-directed learning alone.

A great deal of balancing and interweaving is necessary, in other words, between learning that is truly self-directed by students as individuals and learning that is structured, inspired, activated, provoked by teachers, parents, and community members, as well as shaped by external validating institutions like colleges, the state Department of Education, and our accreditor. These are the considerations that have guided us as we put our values into practice, and lead us to a model we call *self-directed learning, together.*

Self-directed learning, together is a hybrid approach that balances student-led learning with teacher-initiated educational experiences, peer learning, and participation in school culture and community life. Students shape their own learning goals, projects, and pathways, while also engaging in interdisciplinary, project-based curriculum designed by teachers and linked to core competencies. This balancing of student and adult leadership in learning is understood as a productive tension that guides practice rather than a problem to be resolved.

Curriculum

Below is a snapshot of what self-directed learning, together (see above) might look like at Canoe Valley. For more, see the Curriculum Overview section of our draft Long Range Plan.

Self-Directed, Project-Based Learning: Students learn through interdisciplinary projects that replace traditional classes, and that balance their interests and lived experience with teacher-initiated experiences and project arcs.

Play and Exploration: Students have ample time for purely self-chosen, open-ended activities that are understood as foundational modes of learning, rich sources of future projects, and essential supports for wellbeing.

Mentorship: Students and teachers engage in regular 1-on-1 mentorship sessions that support project design, competency pathways, problem-solving, and emotional wellbeing. Teachers, students, and families participate in care teams that support students on their educational journeys.

Peer Learning: Students learn in mixed-age communities where collaboration, observation, shared projects, and participation in school culture spark their learning and development.

Learning Goals and Competency Pathways: Teachers provide learning experiences and initiate projects, or areas of project work, that support whole-person development as outlined above. Projects are linked to a focused and distilled set of core competencies through what we call competency pathways. These are ways of engaging with core skills and knowledge that evolve over time, with increasing student ownership from the lower to the upper level and attention to students' expected post-secondary paths. Core subjects are approached as interconnected areas of activity rather than isolated disciplines, framed by questions that provoke interdisciplinary inquiry. They include modified versions of traditional K-12 subject areas like communication arts, scientific inquiry, quantitative reasoning, and fine and practical arts, as well as less-traditional subjects aligned with the school's values like ecological arts, appropriate design, and practical life and wellness.

Documenting Learning: Learning is documented through multimedia portfolios and collaboratively written learning narratives that reflect engagement, expression, challenges, and growth over time. There are semesterly collaboration and service-learning requirements, as well as a capstone service-learning project. There is also an external validation requirement in the upper level that might

include standardized tests like the ACT, but might also include juried exhibitions or competitions, apprenticeship sign-offs, or externally validated rites of passage.

Electives: Electives deepen and extend the core learning program. Elective classes may employ a variety of pedagogical models. A list of offerings is shaped collaboratively by students and teachers.

School Culture and Community Life: To deepen whole-person learning we envision daily gathering circles, weekly check-in circles, school rituals, teambuilding activities, quarterly showcases, and (especially in the upper level) committee work that supports the life of the school.

Co-Curricular Activities: Co-Curricular activities are not separate from, but are interwoven with the school's core curriculum. They include expeditions, apprenticeships, committee work, service-learning, and partnerships with community organizations.

A Note on a (Possible) Supplementary Program in Reading and Math: Depending on interest, the school may provide two programs geared explicitly toward the development of strong foundations in literacy and numeracy: a daily independent reading program inspired by the Book Whisperer model (for example), and a regular math practice program inspired by the Math for Love model (for example—think puzzles, games, rich tasks).

A Note on Inclusion: The whole-person learning program outlined here provides clear paths to cultivating a welcoming and inclusive school campus, especially in terms of our focus on self-affirmation, expression, and respect for difference. We believe schools thrive when students feel safe being themselves, and when curriculum and teaching is responsive to differences in students' unique lived experiences, abilities, and ways of seeing the world.

A Note on the School Campus and Educational Farm: The school's outdoor campus and planned educational farm are central to the learning we envision at Canoe Valley. We are developing spaces that support learning in ecological arts and regenerative farming, fostering development of hands-on, lived knowledge and connection to place.